THE OPERATING MANUAL · NOT THE MOTIVATION ENGINE

AESDR.

A 12-lesson sales survival course for first-1-to-2-year SDRs and AEs in startup SaaS.

This document distills the binding visual and verbal canon for AESDR. It is the source of truth for design generation in any Claude Design session seeded with this PDF.

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The active palette is editorial. The dark palette is retired and not to be revived in new work.

--CREAM
#FAF7F2

Default page background. Every surface starts here.

--INK
#1A1A1A

Default body text. Default Rowan display color.

--CRIMSON
#8B1A1A

Primary accent. CTAs, hero left panel, Michael's voice color, terminal cursor.

--MUTED
#6B6B6B

Secondary text, mono labels, fine print.

--LIGHT
#E8E4DF

Subtle dividers, low-emphasis surfaces, card borders.

--IRIS
`linear-gradient(90deg, …)`

Reserved shimmer accent. Brand wordmark, the single primary CTA, role tokens, ambient lines, deck numerals — only.

RETIRED · DO NOT REVIVE

#020617 · #0F172A · #1E293B · #10B981 (--theme) · #EF4444 (--coral) · #38BDF8 (--cobalt) · #F59E0B (--amber) · #8B5CF6 (--violet)

Five fonts, each owning a register. Nothing else gets imported without an explicit canon update.

--DISPLAY

'Playfair Display', Georgia, serif

Stop surviving. Start owning it.

Headlines, role labels, masthead-level type. Italic 900wt is the signature weight.

--SERIF

'Source Serif 4', Georgia, serif

Body copy. Default page text. The font that carries the operating manual where readers spend most of their time. Calm, neutral, editorial.

--COND

'Barlow Condensed', sans-serif

UI LABELS · BUTTONS · EYEBROWS · ROWAN'S DISPLAY VOICE

--MONO

'Space Mono', monospace

AESDR · WORKSHOP · TERMINAL · CLASSIFIED · TAXONOMIC LABELS

--HAND

'Caveat', cursive

"My home office is my bed. Gerald is my coworker now. He's quiet. Great listener."

Michael's voice and margin annotations *only*. Never used outside that scope.

The iris gradient is the brand's heartbeat. It is rare on purpose.

`linear-gradient(90deg, #FF006E 0%, #FF6B00 17%, #F59E0B 34%, #10B981 51%, #38BDF8 68%, #8B5CF6 85%, #FF006E 100%)`

PERMITTED

— The brand wordmark ***AESDR***

— The single primary CTA per surface

— Role tokens that distinguish AE / SDR

— Thin animated lines as ambient signals (≤2px)

— One iris-text payoff line per surface

— The deck numeral (only place a numeral takes iris fill)

— One accent word inside a headline (max one)

FORBIDDEN

✗ Iris-filled headlines (the whole headline)

✗ Iris backgrounds (panels, cards, surfaces)

✗ Multiple iris CTAs on the same surface

✗ Decorative flourishes (swirls, blobs, halos)

✗ Iris-filled icons (with one canonical exception: the deck numeral)

✗ Iris on body copy

✗ Iris in any retired-palette context

EXAMPLE — IRIS WHERE IT EARNS ITS PLACE

Stop surviving. Start owning it.

GET ACCESS

Two voices, always present, never blended into mush.

ROWAN · THE VOICE THAT CLOSES

EVERY MONTH, THEY RESET YOUR NUMBER TO ZERO.

YOUR ONBOARDING WAS A CRIME SCENE.

YOU ARE NOT BUILDING A CAREER. YOU ARE SURVIVING ONE.

Type: --cond / --display italic 900
Color: --ink on --cream, or white on --crimson
Spirit: Eli Pope. Surgical, declarative, high-status.
Move: "X is not Y. It is Z." Verdict, not argument.

MICHAEL · THE VOICE AT 2AM

My manager asked for a pipeline update. I sent a screenshot of an empty spreadsheet and wrote "minimalist aesthetic." HR laughed. But like, in a concerned way.

LinkedIn told me to "lead with value on every call." So I told a prospect about a really good taco place. Salsa rankings. They did not buy.

Type: --hand (Caveat) — and only Caveat
Color: --crimson on --cream
Spirit: Michael Scott. Confessional, deadpan, named props.
Move: Specific number → context → one-word verdict.

VOICE RATIOS · BY SURFACE

Outreach to partner: 80/20 · Workshop registration: 70/30 · Workshop deck (locked): 75/25 · Workshop deck (ad-lib): 50/50
Confirmation / reminder emails: 70/30 · Replay email: 60/40 · Objection email: 80/20 · Deadline email: 80/20
Disclosure copy: 100/0 · Legal copy: 100/0 · Internal docs: 90/10

If a piece of copy could be lifted onto a LinkedIn carousel without anyone noticing, it is wrong.

BANNED VOCABULARY

✗ "Crush it" / "crushing it" / "crush your quota"
✗ "Game-changer" / "game-changing"
✗ "Unlock your potential"
✗ "Mindset"
✗ "Rise and grind" / "grindset" / "hustle culture"
✗ "Thought leader" / "thought leadership"
✗ "Lead with value" / "trusted advisor"
✗ "Synergy" / "leverage" (as a verb)
✗ "Amazing" / "incredible" / unearned superlatives
✗ "Empower" / "empowerment"
✗ "Sales superstar" / "rockstar" / "ninja"
✗ Hype emoji (🚀 💪 🔥) anywhere AESDR appears

REQUIRED SIGNATURE MOVES

The verdict construction. "X is not [thing it pretends to be]. It is [what it actually is]."

The named number. Specific dollars, calls, timelines. Never "many," never "a lot."

The honest disqualification. Every offer-bearing surface names who should not buy.

Identity over technique. "We do not teach you to sell. We teach you to be the person who sells."

Cream-and-crimson visual fingerprint. Identifiable at thumbnail size.

CANONICAL TAGLINES

"The operating manual, not the motivation engine."

"Less affiliate empire. More founding vineyard."

"If you want generic sales hype, the internet has a surplus."

"We do not teach you to sell. We teach you to be the person who sells."

"Borrowed trust is a merciless mirror."

"No motivational BS. No 'crush your quota' energy."

"This isn't corporate-y but it will advance your career."

Eight patterns carry the brand. Reuse them.

EDITORIAL SPLIT HERO

01

Stop surviving.
Start owning it.

50/50 split · crimson left / cream right · ghost numeral · iris accent word in headline

TERMINAL BLOCK ON CREAM

```
> scanning your phone...
> found: 11 productivity apps.
> least productive person you know.
```

Mono prompt lines · iris-text payoff line · cursor blink in --crimson

CLASSIFIED DOSSIER CARD

Q01

IS THIS JUST ANOTHER MOTIVATIONAL SALES COURSE?

Nope. No guru stuff. No "crush it" motivation. This is solve...

CLASSIFIED

Blurred body · classified stamp at -2° · hover-to-reveal in production

DECK-STACK PEEL CARD

BUILDING REAL CAMARADERIE 01

"When's the last time your team felt like an actual team?"

Iris numeral · cond title · Caveat description in crimson · iris bar at foot

WARNING BOX (ON CRIMSON)

CONTENT WARNING

Uncomfortable truths about your **pipeline**, your **commission check**, and your **relationship status**.

1px white border at .2 opacity · mono eyebrow with circle-icon · serif body

EDITORIAL BODY SECTION

SECTION LABEL

One price. Lifetime access.

Mono section label · display italic 900 headline · 24pt iris divider rule

Icons are typographic infrastructure, not decoration. Custom-only. No commercial sets.

SEED INVENTORY · TWO REGISTERS

Official (Rowan-aligned: --cond / --mono / --display, geometric, 1.0–1.5px stroke, no fill) · **Annotated** (Michael-aligned: --hand, hand-drawn, off-axis)

.warn-icon	.term-dot	.faq-stamp	.corner	ghost numeral	.term-cursor
!	●●●	CLASSIFIED	⌜ ⌟	01	> ▮

BANNED · NEVER IMPORT

Heroicons · Feather · FontAwesome · Lucide · Material · Bootstrap Icons · Phosphor · Tabler · any commercial icon set. No emoji as iconography in the Official register. No filled bicolor / Material-style two-tone icons. No iris-filled icons (the deck numeral is the only canon exception).

VISUAL QA · FIVE-QUESTION CHECK

Every visual-bearing surface passes these five before it ships.

01

Thumbnail. At 200×200, identifiably AESDR with no logo visible?

02

Tokens. All colors and fonts referencing canon tokens?

03

Iris. Used only on permitted surfaces (CTA / wordmark / role / ambient / deck numeral / one accent word)?

04

Icons. Seed inventory or approved extension only? No commercial set?

05

Voice. First 20 words identifiably AESDR?

— End of canon, v1.1.

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